Match the goal to the benefit - complete text version

Customers rarely ask about servers or bandwidth. They ask how to reduce costs, move faster and reach new customers. In this activity you will read four short business scenarios, decide which cloud benefit best supports each company’s goal, and choose the sentence you would actually say to that customer. Then you will test your judgement when the same companies change their goals. For each scenario, first choose the cloud benefit that best supports the goal. Then choose the sentence you would say to the customer. If a choice is not right, the feedback explains why and you can try again. Finally, match four changed goals to benefits. The companies are fictional. This activity is not scored, and nothing you choose or write is stored or sent anywhere unless you save a text file yourself. Allow about 15 minutes.

How to use this version

You can do every stage on paper or in a document. Read each scenario, choose the cloud benefit that best supports the goal, then choose the sentence you would say to the customer. Read the feedback for every option and compare it with your choices. If you chose differently, work out why before moving on. At the end, match the four changed goals to benefits.

The four cloud benefits

Four cloud benefits that business leaders care about, and what each one means.

- Cost savings: Businesses can avoid large upfront hardware costs and may reduce spending by using capacity as needed, but they still need to check usage, commitments and total cost.
- Flexibility: Businesses can add or remove computing resources where services and setup allow, helping capacity better match changing demand within service limits.
- Faster time-to-market: Ready-made development and test environments can reduce infrastructure setup work, helping teams build and test sooner.
- Global reach: A provider’s network of regions can help companies serve customers in more places without building infrastructure in each country, depending on service choice, connectivity and data requirements.

Scenario 1 of 4: Sto Lat Select

Sto Lat Select is a large lifestyle retailer known for its curated range of home and wellness products. The company experiences major traffic spikes during seasonal campaigns and product launches, but for most of the year its online sales are moderate. Maintaining high-capacity systems throughout the year has become increasingly costly,

tying up funds that could be used for marketing and product innovation. Leadership wants to optimise spending while still making sure their systems perform smoothly during peak shopping periods.

A. Which cloud benefit best supports the goal?

- Cost savings - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. The cloud can help avoid large upfront hardware costs and make it easier to increase capacity for peak periods, but they still need to review usage, commitments and total cost.
- Flexibility - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The traffic spikes are the situation, and flexibility is part of how the cloud copes with them. But the goal leadership states is to optimise spending.
- Faster time-to-market - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The cloud can speed up launches, but nothing here says leadership wants to get to market sooner.
- Global reach - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The cloud supports global expansion, but this scenario is about spending, not new regions.

What gave it away: Leadership wants to optimise spending while still making sure their systems perform smoothly during peak shopping periods.

B. What would you say?

Now choose the sentence you would say to this customer.

- “With the cloud, you can increase capacity for busy periods instead of buying for peak demand all year, which may help you manage costs more carefully while still supporting shopping peaks.” - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. It starts from their goal, explains what changes in plain words and links it to what they want to spend on.
- “Our platform offers on-demand compute provisioning with automated capacity management.” - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. This describes technology, not their goal. Customers rarely ask about servers or bandwidth. They ask how to reduce costs.
- “The cloud will cut your costs in half.” - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Nothing supports that figure, and an unsupported number damages trust. Say what changes for them, not how much.

Scenario 2 of 4: Laconia Energy Systems

Laconia Energy Systems is a mid-sized company that designs renewable-energy grids for regional municipalities. Each new project brings different technical requirements and timelines. Some demand large bursts of data analysis to model energy loads, while others move at a slower pace. Managing infrastructure for both extremes has proven inefficient, because their existing systems cannot easily adjust to fluctuating workloads. The operations director wants to take on new contracts quickly without overcommitting resources, and leadership is looking for a solution that lets their computing capacity expand or contract smoothly based on project needs.

A. Which cloud benefit best supports the goal?

- Cost savings - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The cloud can reduce costs, but the company’s main goal is to adapt to changing workloads, not to manage its budget.
- Flexibility - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. The cloud can let businesses add or remove computing resources as needs change, where the service and setup support it.
- Faster time-to-market - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The cloud can speed up development cycles, but Laconia’s need is not launch speed.
- Global reach - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Cloud services can extend global access, but this scenario is about fluctuating workloads.

What gave it away: Leadership is looking for a solution that lets their computing capacity expand or contract smoothly based on project needs.

B. What would you say?

Now choose the sentence you would say to this customer.

- “We provide horizontally scalable compute clusters with automated orchestration.” - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. This is technical language, and it answers a question the customer has not asked. Speak to the goal: taking on new contracts without overcommitting.
- “For a large modelling job, you could add computing capacity and reduce it afterwards, if the service and setup support those changes. That can help you take on work without keeping spare capacity for every project.” - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. It links the capacity changes directly to the goal of winning contracts without overcommitting.
- “You will never run out of capacity on any project.” - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. An absolute promise like this is not supported by the case, and a customer will test it. Describe what the cloud lets them do and leave out the guarantee.

Scenario 3 of 4: Solitude Innovations

Solitude Innovations is a young technology company developing analytics tools for startup clients. The company is preparing to release a new product that will let early-stage businesses forecast market trends more accurately. The engineering team is under pressure to deliver quickly to stay ahead of competitors, and building and testing the product internally could take months, delaying the launch and increasing costs. The product manager wants to shorten the development timeline and deploy faster without compromising performance or security, and leadership is determined to reach the market before larger competitors introduce similar solutions.

A. Which cloud benefit best supports the goal?

- Cost savings - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The cloud can reduce infrastructure expenses, but that is not the company’s main challenge.

- Flexibility - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The cloud supports flexibility, but the emphasis here is on launching sooner.
- Faster time-to-market - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. The cloud can shorten time to market by providing ready-made development and test environments, so teams spend less time setting up infrastructure and can focus sooner on building and testing.
- Global reach - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The cloud enables delivery to other countries, but that is not Solitude Innovations' focus.

What gave it away: The product manager wants to shorten the development timeline and deploy faster, and leadership is determined to reach the market before larger competitors introduce similar solutions.

B. What would you say?

Now choose the sentence you would say to this customer.

- "You will launch before every competitor." - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Cloud tools may reduce setup work, but they do not guarantee a launch date or a lead over competitors.
- "We provide a fully managed deployment pipeline with container orchestration." - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. This is technology language. The product manager's goal is a shorter timeline, so say what changes in time.
- "Cloud tools can give your team ready-made environments for building and testing, so they spend less time setting up and can move the product forward sooner." - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. It links ready-made environments to a shorter timeline without promising a market outcome.

Scenario 4 of 4: Ashbourne Global

Ashbourne Global is a mid-sized corporate-training firm that provides leadership-development programmes to international organisations. After several successful partnerships in one region, new clients from Europe and Asia have expressed interest in accessing its digital learning platform. Hosting and delivering the same experience to clients around the world would mean expanding its technology infrastructure and support teams across multiple time zones. The executive team wants to reach new global markets quickly while keeping performance, data security and customer satisfaction consistent, without establishing physical offices in each country.

A. Which cloud benefit best supports the goal?

- Cost savings - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The cloud can lower expenses, but Ashbourne Global's main goal is to reach new regions.
- Flexibility - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The cloud offers flexibility for changing workloads, but this scenario is about serving clients in other countries.
- Faster time-to-market - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The cloud can speed up launches, but Ashbourne's challenge is geographic, not development speed.

- Global reach - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. The cloud can help a business reach customers in more regions without building infrastructure in each country, but the right services, regions, connectivity, data needs and security responsibilities still need checking.

What gave it away: The executive team wants to reach new global markets quickly while keeping performance, data security and customer satisfaction consistent, without establishing physical offices in each country.

B. What would you say?

Now choose the sentence you would say to this customer.

- "We provide multi-region points of presence with global load balancing." - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. This is technical language. Their goal is reaching clients in new countries without opening offices, so say that.
- "Clients everywhere will get identical speed and zero downtime." - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. This promises more than you can support. Describe what the cloud makes possible and avoid absolute guarantees.
- "A cloud provider with services in multiple regions can help you serve customers in Europe and Asia from the same platform without opening offices or building infrastructure in each country, if that setup meets your data and connectivity needs." - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. It ties the global network to their goal and answers the concern about offices and infrastructure.

The goal changes

Companies change their priorities. Each statement below gives one of the companies a new goal. Choose the benefit that best supports the new goal.

Changed goal 1 of 4

Sto Lat Select now wants to open its online store to shoppers in other countries.

- Cost savings - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Cost savings: Businesses can avoid large upfront hardware costs and may reduce spending by using capacity as needed, but they still need to check usage, commitments and total cost. This goal is about serving customers in new regions.
- Flexibility - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Flexibility: Businesses can add or remove computing resources where services and setup allow, helping capacity better match changing demand within service limits. This goal is about serving customers in new regions.
- Faster time-to-market - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Faster time-to-market: Ready-made development and test environments can reduce infrastructure setup work, helping teams build and test sooner. This goal is about serving customers in new regions.

- Global reach - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Global reach: A provider’s network of regions can help companies serve customers in more places without building infrastructure in each country, depending on service choice, connectivity and data requirements.

Changed goal 2 of 4

Laconia Energy Systems now says its main worry is the large upfront cost of buying hardware for next year’s projects.

- Cost savings - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Cost savings: Businesses can avoid large upfront hardware costs and may reduce spending by using capacity as needed, but they still need to check usage, commitments and total cost.
- Flexibility - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Flexibility means adding or removing resources on demand. This goal is about avoiding a large upfront purchase.
- Faster time-to-market - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Faster time-to-market: Ready-made development and test environments can reduce infrastructure setup work, helping teams build and test sooner. This goal is about avoiding large upfront spending.
- Global reach - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Global reach: A provider’s network of regions can help companies serve customers in more places without building infrastructure in each country, depending on service choice, connectivity and data requirements. This goal is about avoiding large upfront spending.

Changed goal 3 of 4

Solitude Innovations now wants its next feature built and live before a competitor’s release.

- Cost savings - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Cost savings: Businesses can avoid large upfront hardware costs and may reduce spending by using capacity as needed, but they still need to check usage, commitments and total cost. This goal is about building and testing sooner with ready-made environments.
- Flexibility - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Flexibility: Businesses can add or remove computing resources where services and setup allow, helping capacity better match changing demand within service limits. This goal is about building and testing sooner with ready-made environments.
- Faster time-to-market - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Faster time-to-market: Ready-made development and test environments can reduce infrastructure setup work, helping teams build and test sooner.
- Global reach - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Global reach: A provider’s network of regions can help companies serve customers in more places without building infrastructure in each country, depending on service choice, connectivity and data requirements. This goal is about building and testing sooner with ready-made environments.

Changed goal 4 of 4

Ashbourne Global now needs its platform to cope with a sudden rush when a big client signs up, then settle back.

- Cost savings - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Spending matters, but the goal here is capacity that rises and falls with demand.
- Flexibility - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Flexibility: Businesses can add or remove computing resources where services and setup allow, helping capacity better match changing demand within service limits.
- Faster time-to-market - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Faster time-to-market: Ready-made development and test environments can reduce infrastructure setup work, helping teams build and test sooner. This goal is about adding capacity for a short period and releasing it afterwards.
- Global reach - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Global reach: A provider’s network of regions can help companies serve customers in more places without building infrastructure in each country, depending on service choice, connectivity and data requirements. This goal is about adding capacity for a short period and releasing it afterwards.

Reflect and save

You matched four goals to benefits and chose how to say it. Here is a summary of the benefit you matched to each company.

- Sto Lat Select: Cost savings.
- Laconia Energy Systems: Flexibility.
- Solitude Innovations: Faster time-to-market.
- Ashbourne Global: Global reach.

Choose the benefit you would find hardest to explain to a customer. Write the sentence you would say, starting from the customer’s goal instead of technical terms. (optional) In the interactive version, Save my summary downloads your summary as a text file. Reflection is optional, and the summary can be saved without it. Linking a business goal to a cloud benefit, in the customer’s own words, is how technical advantages become business outcomes.

Finish and return

Activity complete — well done! You have matched four customers and their changed goals to cloud benefits. Reflection and saving a summary are optional. Return to FutureLearn and mark this step complete there. This activity does not update your FutureLearn completion status.